

▲ RELIGION

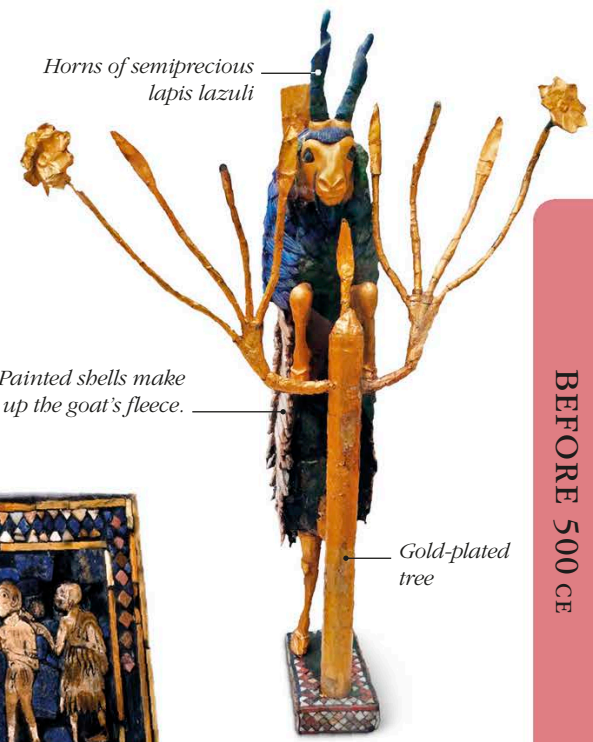
Each city had a chief god, who was worshipped at a stepped mudbrick temple, called a ziggurat. The god's statue was kept in a shrine at the top. This is the ziggurat of Ur, dedicated to Nanna, the moon god, later renamed Sin. The sides of the structure have been restored with modern-day bricks.

The king is depicted larger than the other figures, which shows his status.



The chariots are pulled by onagers—a type of large, horselike donkey.

Enemy soldiers are trampled under the chariots.



Painted shells make up the goat's fleece.

Gold-plated tree

TRADE ▲

Mesopotamia was rich in agricultural products, and exported grain, pottery, and textiles. Raw materials, such as metals, timber, and precious stones were imported from neighboring lands. This statuette of a goat, found in a royal tomb in Ur, is made entirely from materials from distant lands.

Shamash, the god of justice



THE CODE OF HAMMURABI ►

Mesopotamian kings were the first known creators of a system of laws. The most famous of these is the law code of King Hammurabi of Babylon, which was carved on a stele (an upright stone slab) in 1754 BCE. The top of the stele shows the king receiving the laws from Shamash, the Mesopotamian god of justice.

c. 2350 BCE



King Sargon of Akkad, which is a region in the north, conquers Sumer and creates the world's first empire. The Akkadian language later replaces Sumerian in Mesopotamia.

SARGON OF AKKAD

c. 2100 BCE

The first ziggurat temples are built in Ur, Eridu, Nippur, and Uruk. They tower over the flat landscape of Mesopotamia, displaying the power of the city and its god.

c. 1900 BCE

The Amorites, a people from the western deserts, conquer most of Mesopotamia, which they rule from Babylon. They are now known as the Babylonians, and their empire is called Babylonia.